

The Case of the Missing Culprit

For half a century Indians have thrown out their governments, hoping the next lot will be better. We followed the satellites, half a million villages and the missing grain to find out whether it works. The trail led somewhere nobody expected.

By Aakash · An investigation built entirely on Indian data

It happens on counting day, somewhere in India, every few months. The sitting MLA, the man who promised roads, watches his lead melt ballot by ballot. By evening he is out. Firecrackers go off, garlands change necks, and the new man promises roads too.

Few democracies throw out their rulers as readily as India does. In our own count of assembly elections since 1977, a constituency changed hands more often than it stayed loyal. “Vote them out” is close to a national reflex, and it rests on a hopeful theory: fear of losing keeps politicians honest. There is a darker rival theory too. A ruler who knows he will soon be gone grabs what he can while the door is open.

So we asked a simple question with a hard answer. If India could choose its rule, which would serve ordinary people best? Throw every government out after five years, after ten, after fifteen, or only when it fails? We set out to answer it with no opinions, only evidence from India itself.

THE EVIDENCE ROOM

We collected the results of every state assembly election since 1977 across some 4,100 constituencies. We added satellite pictures of India at night, because lights are hard to fake and official numbers are not, and census records for more than half a million villages. Twenty years of state budgets went in too, along with the sworn affidavits of over 90,000 election candidates and government records of subsidised grain. Then we went looking for the culprit.

CLUE ONE: THE COIN TOSS

Detectives need a fair comparison, and elections offer one. When a seat is won by a whisker, the result is close to a coin toss. The places where the sitting party lost by a hair look just like the places where it survived by a hair. The only real difference is who rules next.

So we watched both kinds of places from space for four years after the vote. They glowed the same. Throwing the incumbent out by a whisker made no visible difference to how fast a constituency grew.

CLUE TWO: THE VILLAGE LEDGER

Between 2001 and 2011, India's villages got roads, electricity, schools and health centres at a remarkable pace. Who got them? Not the villages whose MLA belonged to the ruling party, and not the ones that had just thrown their MLA out. The pattern was cold and mechanical. Big villages got more, villages that were

furthest behind caught up, and tribal villages were left behind, whichever party sat in the state capital.

It was as if a machine was running India's villages on its own formula, and nobody in the chair was touching the controls.

CLUE THREE: THE BUDGET

Everyone knows governments splash out before elections. Except, in twenty years of state budgets, they mostly did not. The last budget before a vote looked much like any other, and the spending mix barely changed whoever was in charge.

CLUE FOUR: FOLLOW THE MONEY

The obvious suspect is corruption. Black money leaves no receipts, but it does leave footprints. Candidates must declare their wealth each time they contest, so we compared politicians who narrowly won with those who narrowly lost and then stood again. The winners' declared wealth grew a little faster, though not by enough to prove anything. The real loot, of course, is never declared.

One detail nagged. It was the first-timers whose fortunes grew fastest, not the old hands. Economists have a name for this, the “roving bandit”: a ruler passing through has every reason to grab quickly. And places that narrowly elected a candidate facing criminal cases grew no slower than places that narrowly rejected one.

The second footprint was grain. In 2004–05, about half of the subsidised grain the government released never reached the families it was meant for. By 2011–12 the loss was closer to four in ten. The biggest clean-ups came in Bihar, Chhattisgarh and Odisha, under governments that stayed in power and rebuilt the ration system. Tamil Nadu, where power swings back and forth, stayed relatively clean throughout. Changing the government did not plug the leak. Changing the system did.

THE TWIST

Just as the case seemed to go cold, a clue appeared. States where the same party ruled for a second or third term in a row seemed to grow a little slower. Was this the smoking gun? Should we force governments out?

Good detectives know some clues are planted, and here the planter was the voter. Indians do reward growth, and they re-elect governments after good years. But good years often come from a kind monsoon or a national boom, and luck rarely repeats. So a second

term can look worse even if the government changed nothing at all.

We tested this directly. We built 400 imaginary Indias in which long rule had no effect whatsoever, and let their voters behave exactly as real Indians do. The imaginary Indias showed the same “slowdown”. Most of the clue was an illusion created by the voters themselves.

The same trap swallows the idea of voting purely on performance. A government’s good term did not predict a good next term. What voters rewarded was, mostly, luck.

Voters were not rewarding good government. They were rewarding good weather.

THE VERDICT

For the final test, we ran India forward fifty years, two thousand times over, under eight different rules. They were today’s voters as they are; forced change every five, ten or fifteen years; re-electing only governments that beat their state’s usual growth; and never changing at all. Every rule faced exactly the same droughts, booms and crises.

No rule reliably won. Forcing a change every five years came out ahead in 62 of every 100 futures, barely better than a coin toss. Keeping governments only when they performed changed almost nothing. Inequality between rich and poor states ended up the same whichever rule we chose.

SO WHO DID IT?

The culprit was never the face in the chair. In every clue, what moved people’s lives was the machinery: how a ration scheme is built, the formula that sends roads to big villages first, whether a tribal hamlet is counted at all. Changing the face at the top, often or rarely, barely touched it.

That is not a case for giving up on voting. It is a case for voting on something else. The governments that cut the theft of grain were the ones that rewired the system, not the ones that came and went. The question to ask a candidate is not whether he is new or old. It is what he will rebuild.

We spent the whole investigation chasing the man in the chair. The evidence kept pointing at the machine.

THE FINE PRINT This investigation could not see everything. Satellite lights are a rough gauge of prosperity, reliable state income figures go back only to 2011, and the national government was not tested. Poverty and safety were affected only through growth, because the data showed no other link to who rules. One question remains open: does a second straight term slow a state down slightly? A firm answer could tip the verdict at the margin. Sources: election results (Trivedi Centre for Political Data), satellite, census and affidavit data (SHRUG, Development Data Lab), state budgets (Reserve Bank of India), grain leakage (Drèze and Khera).